

Omega-3 Fatty Acids

Sources of Essential Healthy Fats

Omega-3 fatty acids are a family of polyunsaturated fats that the body cannot make on its own. They are essential for heart, brain, and eye health. The three main types are ALA (from plants), EPA, and DHA (mainly from marine sources).

Why Omega-3s Are Important

Omega-3 fatty acids help maintain healthy cell membranes, support brain and eye development, and contribute to heart health by helping maintain healthy blood fats. ALA is found in plant foods, while EPA and DHA are found mainly in fish and seafood. The body can convert some ALA to EPA and DHA, but only in small amounts.

Food Sources

Plant sources of ALA include flaxseeds, chia seeds, walnuts, and hemp seeds. Marine sources of EPA and DHA include fatty fish such as salmon, sardines, and mackerel. Algae-based supplements provide EPA and DHA for those who do not eat fish.

Suggested Items:

- Flaxseeds - approximately 2.3 g ALA per tablespoon (ground)
- Chia seeds - approximately 2.5 g ALA per tablespoon
- Walnuts - approximately 1.3 g ALA per ounce
- Salmon - approximately 1.5 g EPA+DHA per 3 ounces
- Sardines - approximately 1.2 g EPA+DHA per 3 ounces
- Algae-based supplements - varies, often 200-500 mg per serving

Reference Table

Food	Omega-3 Type	Amount
Flaxseeds	ALA	2.3 g/tbsp
Chia seeds	ALA	2.5 g/tbsp
Walnuts	ALA	1.3 g/oz
Salmon	EPA+DHA	1.5 g/3 oz
Sardines	EPA+DHA	1.2 g/3 oz

Conclusion

Including a mix of plant and marine omega-3 sources supports overall intake. Ground flaxseeds are absorbed better than whole seeds, which can pass through undigested.